

PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

EYE ON THE PRIZE
CM Ashok Gehlot arrives with his 'election budget' papers

sion saved his government, coming as they did at the last minute (though his second tenure had seen the innovative free generic medicines scheme being rolled out). This time, Gehlot's messaging is unambiguous: he's going to town as a welfare magician who started waving his wand from the very first year. An effective broadcasting of that image is a must for him if he wants to undo some of the damage his infighting with Sachin Pilot has caused party and governance.

In a first-ever post-budget move, chief secretary Usha Sharma issued a letter to all bureaucrats at the level of secretary and above on February 13 asking them to start working on the budget announcements, immediately where only administrative orders were needed, within a fortnight where the concurrence of finance or personnel department was required, and to submit proposals within 15 days where specific financial approvals were mandatory.

The sense of urgency is understandable. There are some massive rollouts: inflation relief, an ambitious medical insurance coverage, major relief on electricity charges, compensation to cattle owners who suffered losses with the lumpy cow disease, a softer cushion on the Centre's Ujjwala scheme, a minimum income guarantee scheme, a Rs 200 crore gig workers relief fund, regularisation of all contractual employees, and extension of free education to boys. But he has to prove his administrative skills in bringing them to life given that the state's record on execution has been patchy. That his dearness/ inflation relief alone will cost Rs 19,000-odd crore in a state with one of India's worst debt-to-GSDP ratios, touching 40 per cent, is secondary for now. What matters to Gehlot is that his largesse wins him a return gift in the shape of a popular vote—or at least that he goes down as a well-meaning, caring chief minister.

DOLE IT OUT

- Free power of 100 units for every household. 1.1 million farmers consuming up to 2,000 units won't be charged
- Gas cylinders at Rs 500 perunit to 7.6 million families
- Minimum income guarantee scheme; Rs 200 crore gig workers' relief fund
- Major boost for state's Chiranjeevi universal insurance policy

Chiranjeevi, his flagship universal insurance policy, has got a major boost, extending floating coverage from Rs 10 lakh to up to Rs 25 lakh, free for all BPL and APL families and for just Rs 850 a year for everyone else. Many private hospitals have been included in the scheme, besides all state-owned ones. Theoretically, this means the state bears almost the entire cost of indoor treatment for everyone almost for free, and that government hospitals provide most medicines and tests—including MRI and high-resolution CT scans where available—for free. The scheme also includes an accidental death coverage of Rs 10 lakh. State hospitals have so far failed to evolve a good mechanism to offer services on par with private hospitals, with numerous complaints of patients being pushed from one window to the other, long queues and lack of medicines. And in private hospitals, patients are often slapped with charges on the grounds that certain treatments are excluded under the scheme. Still, it covers a major part of expensive private treatment. So what if the fisc lands in the trauma ward?

Power is another major area of outreach that will dim the treasury's wattage considerably—100 units per household free, up from 50 units, which translates into savings of approximately Rs 750 a month. In a state where electricity tariffs are among the highest in India, it's a big relief to consumers. About 10 million of them will be getting no bill. Another 1.1 million farmers consuming up to 2,000 units won't be charged either—the earlier limit was 1,000 units. The hitch? The state has yet to release Rs 17,000 crore dues to its power companies, who owed Rs 11,000 crore to the Centre in 2022.

One piece of largesse seems